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What Is a Sales Lead?



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer
July 01, 2014

Before starting up your affiliate career, it is important to familiarize yourself with the most ubiquitous term in affiliate marketing: sales lead. If the term *sales lead* is unfamiliar to you, this article will help you understand the basics of this concept, from finding to qualifying sales leads. So, what is a sales lead?

Sales Lead Definition

It's important to always remember that a person is behind the contact info provided with that sales lead. A person becomes a lead when that person's credentials and interests match that of a potential customer and that person has the potential to convert. It is important to remember that you must qualify that person's credentials to verify if they do actually match to your advertiser's needs in order to get paid.

An unvetted sales lead is probably unacceptable to your client, so it's up to you to qualify your leads before sending them on to the lead buyer's sales funnel.

Sales Lead Qualification



You should, by this point, have a range of potential lead qualifications that you are prepared to ask your visitors. Your leads may trickle in, or come in a wave, so it is important to find ways to automate your sales lead qualification process. There are multiple software packages available to assist you in this process.

[InfoUSA](#) among other companies offer services aimed to help with the pre-qualifying legwork. The qualification services may come with explicit rules and guidelines you may need to follow. It is important to research any company you hope to work with to qualify your leads. Your lead qualifications may vary between industries which makes a qualified lead unique to you. Case in point, an ideal customer for a new fishing rod may be profoundly different than one for online dating.

If you're still lost on what makes for a good sales lead, consider discussing with your advertiser or affiliate network what specifically makes a good qualified lead for your specialized portion of the market, or the niche that you serve as an affiliate.

Sales Lead Scoring

Based on what you know about each lead, as well as the actions each perform on your site, you can assign a value to each lead. Pamela Vaughn, HubSpot's lead blog strategist, explains "For example, you would likely rank a vice president-level lead who has spent time on both your products and pricing page [higher than an intern- or coordinator-level lead](#) with the same behavior."

You might not be swimming in leads. In that case, it may not be worth your time assigning a score to each of them. MarketingSherpa's [B2B Benchmarking Report](#) states that only 21% of B2B marketers are using a lead scoring program.

Sales Lead Form

You may be asking how you might find such pertinent information like your lead's job title, company size and company type. Use a simple form on your site to capture and correlate all vital information that is freely given by each lead.

This process, along with lead qualifying and scoring, is a way to help translate a visitor's details, digital body

language, and modus operandi into a road map that may give the affiliate and advertiser an understanding of the next step to take with a new sales lead.

Some affiliate networks provide sales lead forms for their affiliates. This makes the potentially arduous task of defining what is needed in your sales lead form a moot question. Usually, the questions posed on a sales lead form will provide the information your advertiser is looking for.

How to Get Sales Leads



It is advisable to avoid the deceptive offers on the Internet that claim to offer millions of relevant leads in bulk for a price. Those leads will most likely be useless to your specific needs. Since these large caches of digital information do not pertain to a specific niche, you'll likely waste your money on leads that have next to no chance of converting.

The most surefire way to secure quality leads is by presenting your site's visitors with something of value. This may be through instructional or informative posts, step-by-step how-to posts, or merely a personal story that evokes an emotional shift in your visitors. Presenting a powerful and personal story can do more for your conversion numbers than all the cheaply bought bulk lead lists on the Internet.

Getting sales leads begins with getting visitors to your site. PPC advertising, SEO, and great emotionally-charged content will be some of your best tools in attracting visitors to your site.

Takeaway

How you approach gathering sales leads will shape your success as an affiliate marketer. Generating sales leads means money in your pocket. Your advertising partner or affiliate network will likely designate what constitutes a good sales lead. In the end, it is your job to attract visitors to your site and provide a reason for each visitor to convert.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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